

Beyond Pink

**A Breast Cancer Detection Awareness &
Assistance eBook for Women & Men in Rural
Communities**

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Welcome to *Beyond Pink*

Welcome to *Beyond Pink*, an educational eBook about breast cancer awareness and early detection.

Breast cancer can affect both women and men (Miwaylife.co.za, 2020). Learning about breast cancer, knowing the possible warning signs and understanding when to seek medical help can help people make informed decisions about their health.

This eBook provides information in simple and easy-to-understand language. It is designed to make breast cancer information more accessible, especially for people living in rural communities.



What is the purpose of this eBook?

The purpose of *Beyond Pink eBook* is to provide simple and reliable information about breast cancer.

It aims to help readers:

- Understand breast cancer.
- Recognise possible warning signs.
- Learn about early detection.
- Understand common myths and facts.
- Know when to seek medical help.

Who is this eBook for?

Beyond Pink is mainly designed for women and men living in rural communities.

It can also help:

- Families and caregivers.

- Community health workers.
- Students and teachers.
- Anyone interested in learning about breast cancer.

The information is written in simple language to make it easy to understand.

Why does breast cancer awareness matter in rural communities?

People in rural communities may face challenges such as long distances to healthcare facilities, limited resources and unreliable health information.

Breast cancer awareness can help people:

- Recognise unusual changes.
- Understand the importance of early action.
- Avoid harmful myths.
- Know when to seek professional help.

What can and cannot this eBook do?

This eBook CAN:

- Provide breast cancer information.
- Explain signs, symptoms and risk factors.
- Share early detection information.
- Address myths and facts.
- Encourage people to seek medical help.

This eBook CANNOT:

- Diagnose cancer.
- Replace a doctor or nurse.
- Replace medical tests or screening.
- Recommend personal treatment.

If you have concerns about your health, speak to a qualified healthcare professional as soon as possible.

How do I use this eBook?

The eBook is designed to work on phones, tablets and computers.

You can:

1. Start with the introduction.
2. Learn about cancer and breast cancer.
3. Explore signs, symptoms and early detection.
4. Check the Myths vs Facts section.
5. Use the Glossary for unfamiliar words.
6. Select your preferred language.
7. Use accessibility features such as audio and screen-reader support.

Breakdown of cancer

What is cancer

Cancer is a disease that happens when some cells in the body begin to grow and divide in an uncontrolled way. Normally, cells grow, divide and die in an organised process. Cancer can develop when this process becomes abnormal. The abnormal cells may form a mass called a tumour. Some tumours are not cancerous, while cancerous tumours can invade nearby tissues and may spread to other parts of the body.

How does cancer develop?

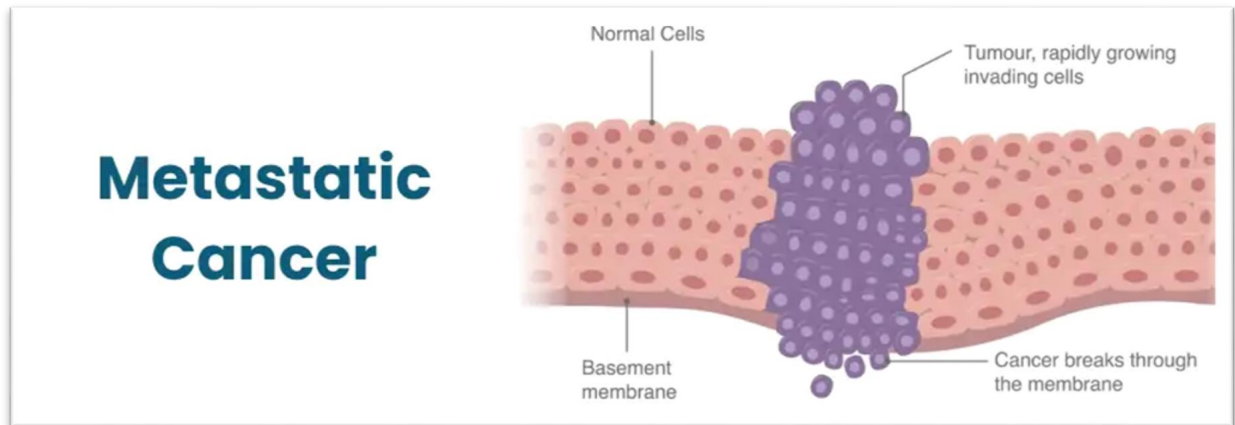
Cancer can develop when changes occur in the cells' instructions, for instance DNA inside a cell becomes changed or damaged., causing them to grow when they should not.

Over time, these abnormal cells may form a tumour. Some tumours are harmless, while cancerous tumours can grow into nearby tissues.

Can cancer spread?

Yes. Some cancers can spread from their original location to other parts of the body.

This process is called **metastasis**



When cancer spreads, it can affect other organs and make treatment more difficult.

Not all cancers spread, especially when they are found and treated early.

What is breast cancer?

Breast cancer is a type of cancer that starts in the cells of the breast.

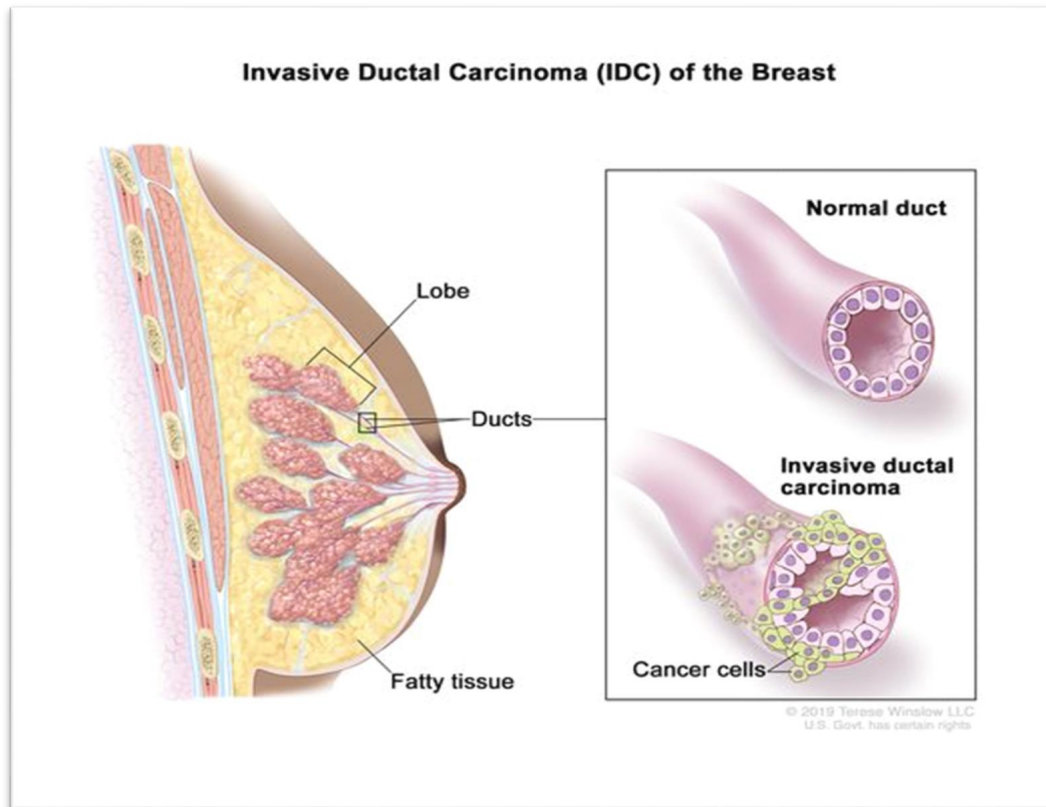
It can occur in both women and men, although it is much more common in women.

Breast cancer can affect different parts of the breast and may develop in different ways.

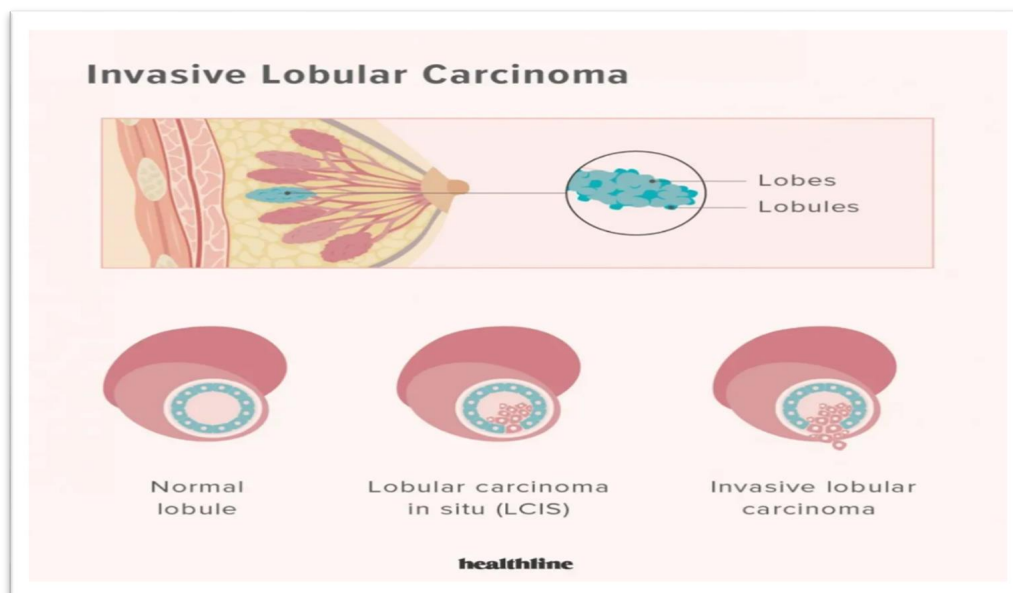
What are the common types of breast cancer?

There are different types of breast cancer. Some common ones include:

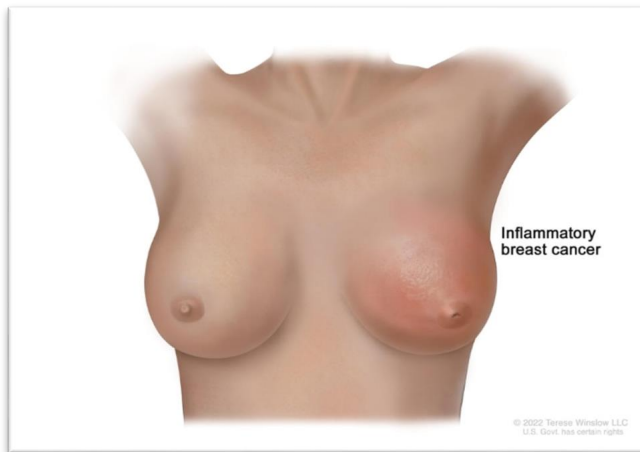
Invasive ductal carcinoma (IDC): A common type of breast cancer that starts in the milk ducts and spreads into nearby breast tissue (Cancer.gov, 2025).



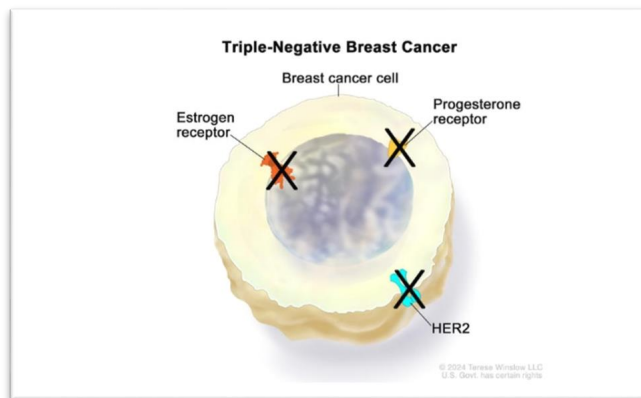
Invasive lobular carcinoma (ILC): A type of breast cancer that starts in the milk-producing glands (lobules) and spreads into nearby tissue (Cancer.gov, 2025).



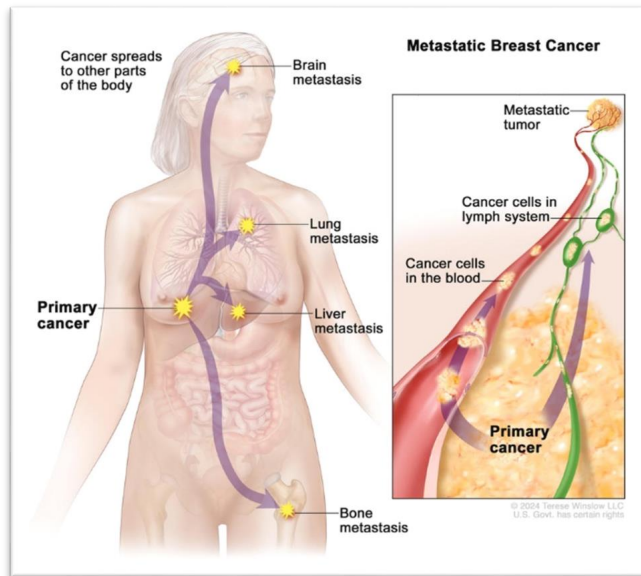
Inflammatory breast cancer: A rare and fast-growing type of breast cancer that can make the breast look red, swollen and inflamed (Cancer.gov, 2025).



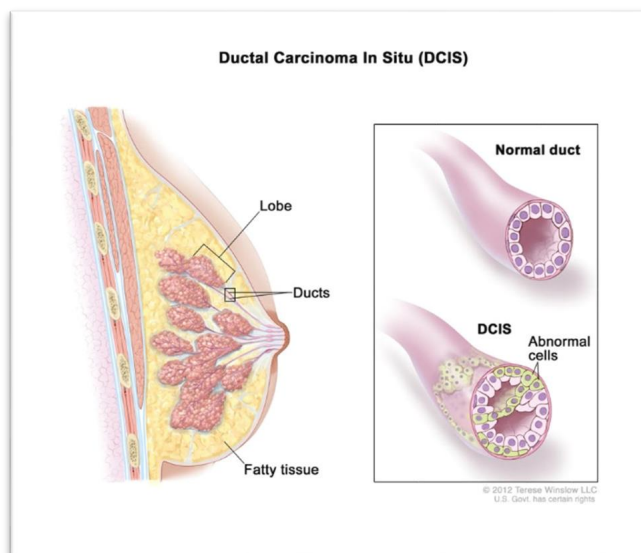
Triple-negative breast cancer: A type of breast cancer that does not have three common receptors or proteins that some breast cancers use to grow (Cancer.gov, 2025).



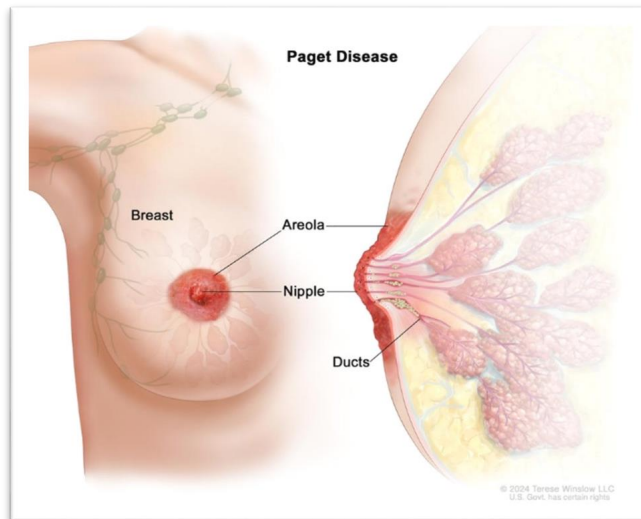
Metastatic breast cancer: Breast cancer that has spread from the breast to other parts of the body and is also known as **Stage 4 breast cancer** (Cancer.gov, 2025).



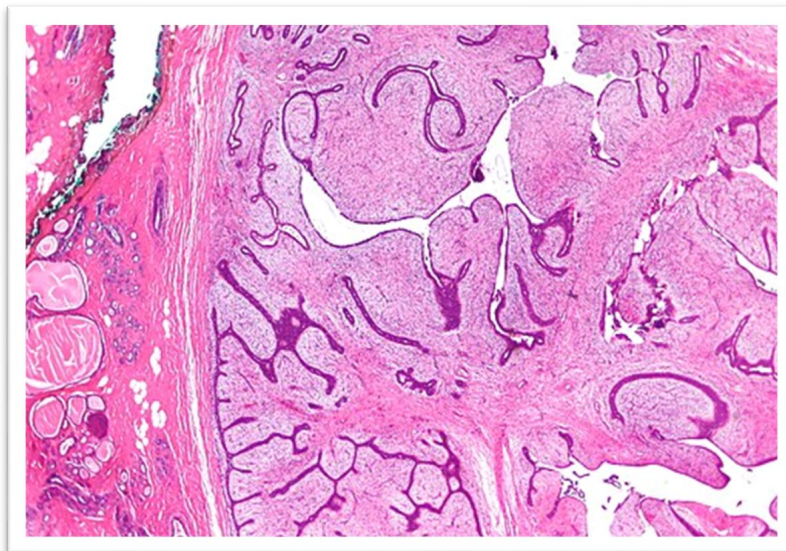
Ductal carcinoma in situ (DCIS): An early form of breast cancer that stays inside the milk ducts and has not spread into surrounding breast tissue (Cancer.gov, 2025).



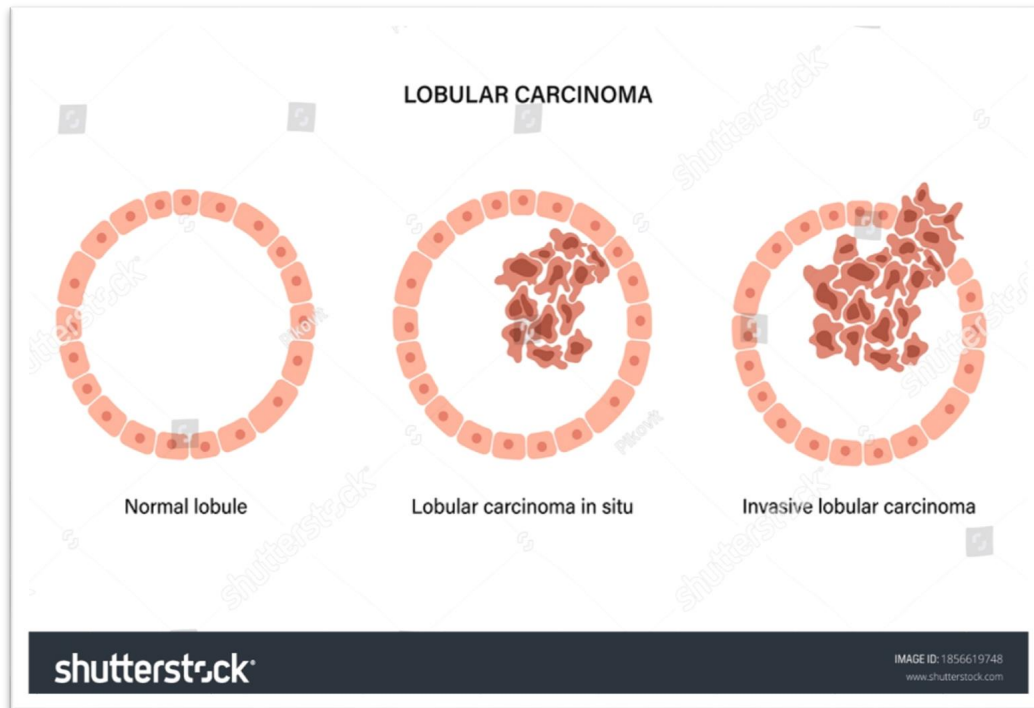
Paget disease of the breast: A rare type of breast cancer that affects the skin of the nipple and the darker area around it (areola) (Cancer.gov, 2025).



Phyllodes tumour: A rare breast tumour that develops in the connective tissue, and most phyllodes tumours are not cancerous (Cancer.gov, 2025).



Lobular carcinoma in situ (LCIS): A condition where abnormal cells develop in the milk-producing glands and increase the risk of developing breast cancer in the future (Cancer.gov, 2025).



A healthcare professional can determine the specific type through medical tests.

Can men get breast cancer?

Yes. Men can get breast cancer too.

Although breast cancer is less common in men, they can still develop the disease because men also have a small amount of breast tissue.

Men should therefore not ignore unusual changes in the breast or chest area.

What are the main risk factors?

A risk factor is something that may increase a person's chance of developing a disease.

Some breast cancer risk factors include:

- Getting older.
- Family history of breast cancer.
- Certain inherited genetic changes.
- Some hormonal factors.
- Certain lifestyle and environmental factors.

Having a risk factor does not mean that a person will develop cancer.

Why is early detection important?

Finding breast cancer early can give a person a better chance of receiving treatment sooner.

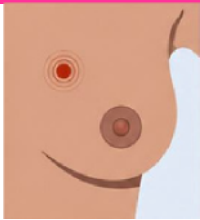
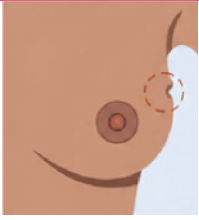
This is why it is important to:

- Know what is normal for your body.
- Pay attention to unusual changes.
- Follow recommended screening advice.
- Seek professional medical help when concerned.

Early awareness can lead to early action.

Symptoms of Breast Cancer

Symptoms of Breast Cancer in Women

		
Changes in Breast Size One breast may suddenly change in size or shape.	Breast or nipple pain The breast or nipple may feel pain, sore or uncomfortable.	Changes in skin texture Changes in skin texture The skin may become rough, thick or look like an orange peel.
		
Dimpling Small dents or dimple-like dips may appear on the breast.	Lymph node changes Lumps or swelling may appear under the skin.	Nipple discharge Liquid may come out of the nipple when the person is not bleeding.
		

Retracted or inverted nipple The nipple may suddenly turn or pull inward	Changes in skin colour The breast skin may become red, darker or look bruised.	Swelling Part or all the breasts may become swollen or feel bigger.
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These symptoms do not always mean that a person has breast cancer. However, any unusual breast change should be checked by a healthcare professional

Symptoms of Breast Cancer in Men

Although breast cancer is much less common in men, unusual changes should still be checked by a healthcare professional.

Men can experience most of the same symptoms as women, including:

- A lump or swelling in the chest or armpit
- Changes in the skin
- Nipple discharge
- A nipple that turns inward
- Pain or tenderness
- Changes in the size or shape of the chest
- A rash or sore around the nipple

For both men and women, changes do not always mean that one has breast cancer, as they can have other causes. However, any new, unusual or persistent breast change should be checked by a healthcare professional.

Screening And Early Detection

Your journey with cancer can be entirely different from another person's. What one person views as normal may be just that, or it could be a reason to look further into things. The most important thing is to do what is best for one's own body to get the appropriate help if necessary.

You may be asking yourself, "where do I even start?", and the following is where.

Breast Self-Examination

A breast self-examination is an early detection method where one does physical and visual examinations of the breasts to keep an eye out for early signs and symptoms of

breast cancer, (Shockney, 2026). This is done to become familiar with what feels and atypical with one's breast tissue.

It is important to be aware of one's breasts so that the slightest changes in their typical feel can be reported to medical professionals and checked out. These may include but are not limited to lumps and skin changes, (Shockney, 2026). Please note that not all abnormalities should be a cause for concern, but it is better to be precautionary than reactionary.

How to do it?

CAN/SA has provided steps on how to do a breast self-examination.

The following is a YouTube video on how to do so:

https://youtu.be/7ef2RF_9U4c?si=nRNXuZMcFGnccEXB

The steps provided in the video are as follows:

1. Mirror Exam
 - Whilst stood in front of the mirror, have a look at any potential physical abnormalities in the look and feel of the breast. These may include dimples, size changes and any potential nipple discharge.
 - Conduct inspection in four ways, namely “arms at sides, arms overhead, hands firmly press on hips and bending forward”, CAN/SA (2019).
2. Laid Down Exam
 - Lay backside down, facing upwards with a pillow elevating your right shoulder and with your right hand under your head.
 - Use four fingers of your left hand “make small circular motions, follow an up and down pattern over the entire breast area, under the arms and up to the shoulder bone, pressing firmly”, CAN/SA (2019)
 - Do the same process just using the right hand on your left breast.
3. Bathing Exam
 - Whilst in the bath or shower, raise your right arm and use your soapy left hand to do the steps broken down in laid down exam and vice versa

Professional Screening Methods

After your self-assessment, the next level of examination is at the professional level. Pay a visit to your nearest healthcare centre if something is detected during your self-examination for further evaluation.

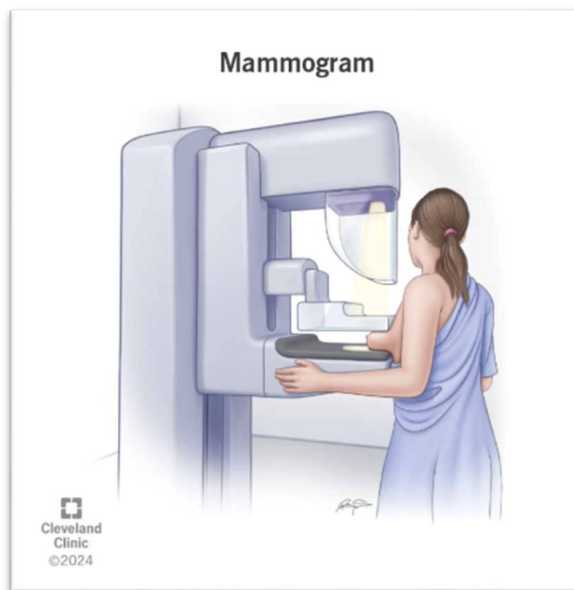
Upon arrival, several screening methods may be used by the healthcare professionals to examine the breast tissue. Such methods include:

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1. Mammography or Mammogram

- A mammogram is an x-ray screening of the breast tissue, which is conducted using low doses of radiation, (Malhotra, n/a).
- 2D mammograms are x-ray images taken from the top and from the side of the breast. 3D images are taken from numerous angles all around the breast, (Malhotra, n/a).

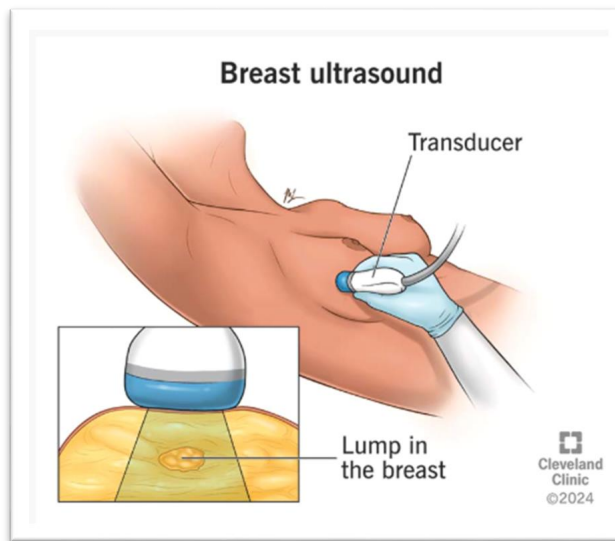
Image showing a patient with their breast being examined in a mammogram machine. Source Cleveland Clinic (2024).



2. Ultrasound

- An ultrasound is when a “technician moves a handheld device (transducer) over your breast and surrounding tissues”, (Cleveland Clinic, 2024).
- It can indicate whether a growth is just a breast lump or a solid mass that requires further inspection.

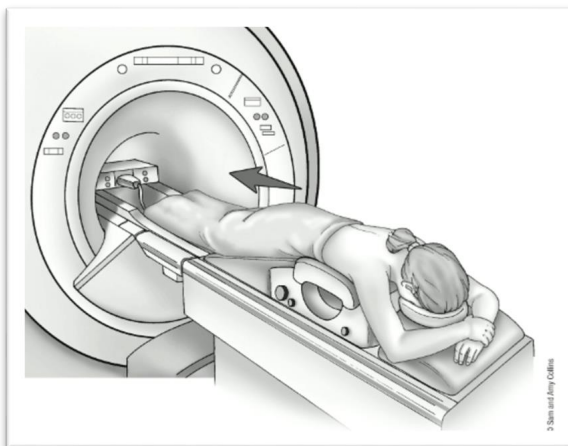
Image showing a patient laying upwards, with an ultrasound machine being used for a breast examination. Source: Cleveland Clinic, (2024)



3. Magnetic Resonance Imaging or an MRI

- An MRI is breast screening that uses radio waves and strong magnets to take high resolution images of the breast tissue, (American Cancer Society, 2026).

Image showing a lady lying face down in an MRI machine. Source: American Cancer Society (2026).



Where to seek Help.

Breast Health Foundation

- Phone: 0860 283 343 / 011 489 1151
- Email: support@mybreast.org.za

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- Address: Netcare Rehabilitation Centre, 18 Dorbie Street, Auckland Park, Johannesburg, 2006 (mybreast.org.za)

CANSA Bedfordview Care Centre / National Head Office

- Phone: 011 616 7662
- Toll-free: 0800 22 6622
- WhatsApp: 072 197 9305 / 071 867 3530
- Email: info@cansa.org.za
- Address: 26 Concorde Road West, Bedfordview, Johannesburg, 2008

CANSA Pretoria Care Centre

- Phone: 012 329 3036
- Email: pretoria@cansa.org.za
- Address: 32 Lys Street, Rietfontein, Pretoria, 0084 (CANSA)

CANSA Durban Care Centre

- Phone: 031 205 9525
- Email: admindurban@cansa.org.za
- General CANSA email: info@cansa.org.za (CANSA)
- Address: 619 Umbilo road, Umbilo, Durban 4001

CANSA Cape Metro Care Centre

- Phone: 021 689 5347
- Email: capemetro@cansa.org.za
- General CANSA email: info@cansa.org.za (CANSA)
- Address: 7 Dunbar street, Athlone, Cape Town, 7760

CANSA Bloemfontein Care Centre

- Phone: 051 444 2580
- Email: ttlali@cansa.org.za
- General CANSA email: info@cansa.org.za (CANSA)
- Address: 90 Melville Drive, Brandwag, Bloemfontein, 9301

CANSA Gqeberha Care Centre

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- Phone: 041 373 5157 / 082 553 9676
- Screening contact email: nwagner@cansa.org.za
- General CANSA email: info@cansa.org.za (CANSA)
- Address: 8 Eden Road, Glendinningvale, Gqeberha, 6001

Reach for Recovery

- National Manager phone: 079 462 3973
- Email: nationalmanager@reach4recovery.org.za
- Pretoria / Gauteng North contact: 076 021 3022
- Pretoria contact email: minahsookane@gmail.com (Reach for Recovery)
- Address: Summit House, Rondebosch Medical Centre, 95 Klipfontein Road, Rondebosch, Cape Town, 7700

PinkDrive

- Johannesburg: 011 998 8022
- Durban: 060 508 3336
- Cape Town: 068 945 1264
- Head Office address: 3 Susan Street, Strydom Park, Johannesburg, 2194 (Pink Drive)

CANSA Rustenburg Care Centre

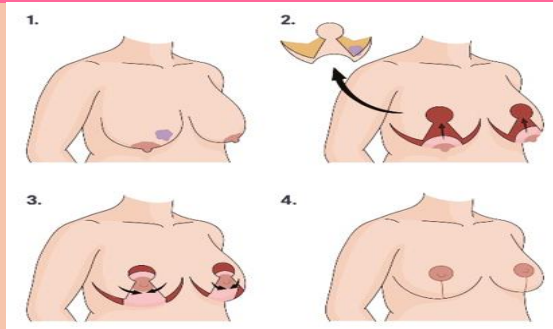
- Phone: 014 533 0694
- General CANSA email: info@cansa.org.za
- CANSA toll-free: 0800 22 6622
- WhatsApp: 072 197 9305 / 071 867 3530 (CANSA)
- Address: 89 Harris Crescent, Sherwood, Durban, 4001

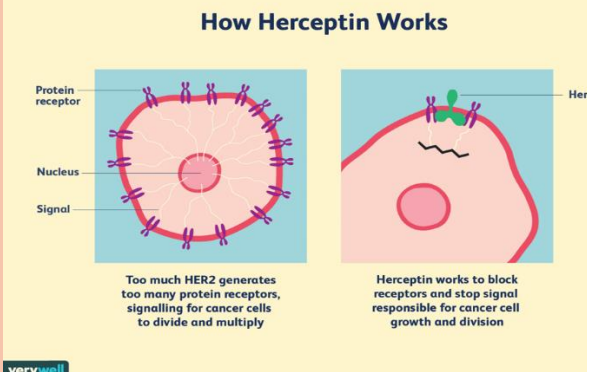
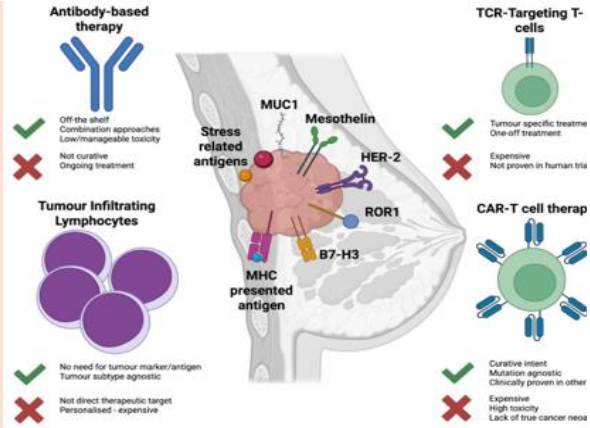
Treatment methods for Breast Cancer

Understanding Breast Cancer Treatment

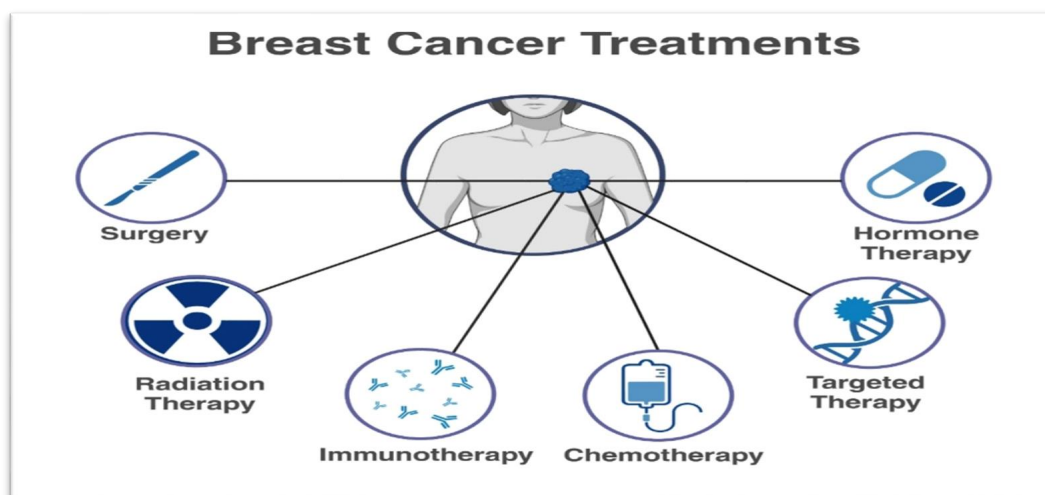
Breast cancer treatment is not the same for everyone. The treatment plan for an individual depends on different factors, including the type and stage of breast cancer. It depends whether the cancer has spread inside their body, their hormone-receptor

status, *HER2 status* and their overall health. Breast cancer treatment is divided into **local treatments**, which treat the cancer in specific areas and **systemic treatments**, which uses medicines that can travel throughout the body (American Cancer Society, n.d.) .

Treatment methods	Main Purpose	Visual representations
Surgery	Surgery is used to remove the tumour or the affected breast tissue.	
Radiation Therapy	It is used to destroy cancer cells in a target area	
Chemotherapy	Uses medicine to destroy or slow cancer cells throughout the body	

Hormone Therapy	Blocks or reduces hormones that can fuel hormone-receptor-positive cancer	
Targeted Therapy	Targets specific proteins or genetic characteristics of cancer cells	How Herceptin Works  Protein receptor Nucleus Signal Too much HER2 generates too many protein receptors, signalling for cancer cells to divide and multiply Herceptin works to block receptors and stop signal responsible for cancer cell growth and division verywell
Immunotherapy	To use and strengthen your immune system to recognise and destroy the cancer.	 Antibody-based therapy ✓ Off-the-shelf ✓ Combination approaches ✓ Low/manageable toxicity ✗ Not curative ✗ Ongoing treatment TCR-Targeting T-cells ✓ Tumour specific ✓ One-off treatment ✗ Expensive ✗ Not proven in human trials CAR-T cell therapy ✓ Curative intent ✓ Mutation agnostic ✓ Clinically proven in other ✗ Expensive ✗ High toxicity ✗ Lack of true cancer neo Tumour Infiltrating Lymphocytes ✓ No need for tumour marker/antigen ✓ Tumour subtype agnostic ✗ Not direct therapeutic target ✗ Personalised - expensive Stress related antigens: MUC1, Mesothelin, HER-2, ROR1, B7-H3, MHC presented antigen

Visual representation of Breast cancer treatments



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Video about Breast cancer treatments

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zo0MNjG3jPY>

Accessibility

Our breast cancer website is designed to be accessible and inclusive for people with different disabilities. To support people with hearing disabilities, videos include captions and subtitles, while important audio information can also be provided in written form. People with visual disabilities can access the website using screen readers, alternative text for images, clear fonts, adjustable text sizes and strong colour contrast. The website also uses simple and clear language, short paragraphs, headings and visual aids to help people with learning or cognitive disabilities understand breast cancer information. In addition, the website is designed to support keyboard navigation and other assistive technologies. By following recognised web accessibility principles, we aim to ensure that everyone, regardless of their disability, has equal access to important information about breast cancer, its symptoms, diagnosis, treatment and support (World Health Organization, 2023; World Wide Web Consortium, 2024).

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Glossary

Cancer a disease where abnormal cells grow and divide uncontrollably.

Chemotherapy a drug treatment that uses powerful chemicals to kill fast-growing cells in the body, primarily used to treat cancer.

Diagnose To identify a disease or health condition through medical examination and tests.

Facts Information that is proven to be true and supported by reliable evidence.

Hormone-receptor status a status that tells doctors whether cancer cells have specific proteins (called receptors) that attach to hormones such as progesterone to fuel their growth.

Hormone Therapy a medical treatment that adds, blocks or removes hormones in the body to manage symptoms, support gender-affirming care or treat specific diseases like cancer.

Immunotherapy a type of medical treatment that uses your body's own immune system to fight diseases like cancer.

Lymph node a small part of the body that helps fight infections and diseases. Lymph nodes are found in areas such as the armpits, neck and near the collarbone.

Mammogram x-ray imagery of the breast taken using a mammogram machine which presses the breast tissue flat to detect any abnormal breast changes.

Metastasis The process where cancer spreads from its original location to other parts of the body.

MRI breast screening that uses radio waves and strong magnets to take high resolution images of the breast tissue.

Myths Common beliefs or ideas that are not supported by reliable evidence.

Nipple The small, raised part in the centre of the breast where breast milk can come out.

Radiation Therapy (also called radiotherapy) a cancer treatment that uses high-energy rays or particles to destroy cancer cells and shrink tumours.

Risk factor Something that may increase a person's chance of developing a disease.

Screening Medical tests used to check for a disease, sometimes before symptoms appear.

Signs Physical changes that may be noticed or observed, such as a lump or swelling.

Surgery a medical procedure where doctors cut, repair or remove body tissues to treat diseases, injuries or other health problems.

Symptoms Changes or problems a person experiences, such as pain or tiredness.

Targeted Therapy a precision cancer treatment that uses drugs to find and

attack specific changes, genes or proteins inside or on cancer cells (American Cancer).

Transducer a handheld device that produces sound waves that bounce off body tissue to create an image based on the different shapes within the breast tissue

Tumour a mass of abnormal cells that forms when cells grow and divide more than they should.

Ultrasound an imaging procedure where a handheld device called a transducer uses magnets and radio waves to take imagery.